# The Insanity of Mary Girard

## By Lanie Robertson

***Suggested Roles:*** ***Actress 1:*** *Mary* ***Actress 2:*** *Furies, Warder, Mrs. Lum, Stephen*

***NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.***

*Mary Girard is bound in the Tranquilizing Chair – used for "excitable patients" who were believed to be insane. Leather straps bind down wrists, arms, chest and ankles. A square box swings down over the head. Mary is a very attractive woman, 29 years old. The Furies circle the chair and lift the box. Mary seems, at first, asleep or in a coma. Then she becomes agitated and strains against her bonds.*

**FURIES:** **(Pg 67)** *(tauntingly)* Mary. Mary Girard. Mary. Girard.

**MARY:** *(screams)* Who are you? Stay away from me! No! Let me out of here. Set me free at once!

**FURIES:** Oh. She's so. Indignant. Quite the fine lady. Isn't she? No one would think. Her husband was. Well-to-do. Would they, Mary?

**MARY:** **(Pg 68-69)** Who are you? What are you? Tell me.

**FURIES:** We're no one. Nothing. Inmates of the asylum. Like you, Mary. Figments of your imagination. A puff. A poof. Of nothing. Nothing, nothing. *(setting MARY free)*

**MARY:** If you are nothing, then I must be mad. I can see you, hear you. *(grabs at them but they elude her)* Tell me where I am? And how long I've been here.

**FURIES:** *(disappointed)* That's too simple. It's no fun. You know that already. The Pennsylvania. Hospital. The same. As it was. This morning.

**MARY:** But I'm not crazy. You know I'm not.

**FURIES:** You must be! Mr. Girard had you admitted. As a lunatic, paying patient. The doctors have agreed. To keep you here. As long as Mr. Girard. Continues to pay. Quite a lucrative account.

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## INTRODUCTION

***ACTRESS 1:*** *In the late 1700's women were expected to be dutiful, subservient housewives, to take care of the children, and to keep order in the house.*
***ACTRESS 2:*** *Men made all the decisions; women were simply expected to listen and obey. Divorce was not an accepted practice.*
***ACTRESS 1:*** *But if a woman behaved in a way that opposed her husband or brought him dishonor, he could legally have her declared insane and have her committed.*
***ACTRESS 2:*** *In the 1700's many perfectly sane women ended up in asylums.*
***ACTRESS 1:*** *Mary Girard was both an opinionated and outspoken believer in equality. She railed against unjust practices.*
***ACTRESS 2:*** *Today she would be called a leader; but in her time there were just vague whispers about . . .*
***TOGETHER:*** *The Insanity of Mary Girard by Lanie Robertson*
***ACTRESS 2:*** *Based on a real-life story of a woman who spent the last 25 years of her life in a mental institution.*

**MARY:** **(Pg 69-70)** *(as the FURIES laugh at her frustration)* It's all a misunderstanding. When I see the doctors, when I speak to Mr. Girard, it will all be corrected. It's a mistake, I tell you. And that chair. I thought I'd go mad.

**FURIES:** She will. In time. She sounds. Stark raving. Mad. That chair is one of the. Prized possessions. And inventions of. Dr. Rush. He positively. Loves it. And. So do we.

**MARY:** I couldn't move. I couldn't see anything. And then my eyes began to tear and I couldn't wipe them. And there was such a roaring in my ears. I thought I would go . . . that it would drive me . . .

**FURIES:** You were only here. Experiencing the effects. Of the Tranquilizing Chair. It's the. Proper treatment. For your type. Of madness. Dr. Rush. Has invented. Two appliances. To be used for. The treatment of. The mad. The gyrator. Or revolving machine. That shakes them up. The other is. The tranquilizing chair. For types like you. Ones subject to claims of. Sanity.

**MARY:** *(furious)* How dare you speak to me like that. I'm Mrs. Stephen Girard! I don't have to tolerate your taunts and jeers. **(Pg 71)** Tell me how to get out of here. Please. Please!

**FURIES:** We can only. Show you. You have to start. At the beginning. By seeing. The warder of. The cells.

********Scene********

**WARDER:** **(Pg 72-73)** *(enters, he is about Mary's age)* Here ye go. In here, Mary. That's yer

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name, ain't it?

**MARY:** *(haughtily)* My name is Mrs. Stephen Girard. You will call me by that name if you address me again.

**WARDER:** Oh no, I don't. I calls ye Mary. I was told by Mr. Girard hisself I was to so call ye.

**MARY:** You don't understand. I came to see the doctor about a personal condition. Where is he, sir? *(pause)* I demand that you take me to the doctor at once!

**WARDER:** Snooty, ain't ye? Wants to see the doctor at once, do she? Well, doctors don't come round at once. They're due sometime week after next. I guess ye'll wait till then, all right *(exits the cell, closing the door)*

**MARY:** **(Pg 74-75)** What are you doing?

**WARDER:** Lockin' the door to yer new home. It's customary.

**MARY:** You can't keep me here. Where am I? Is this a prison?

**WARDER:** That's real insultin', that is. This is the Pennsylvania Hospital. An' ye are in the ward fer the mentally deranged. The place fer lunaticks, in plain speech.

**MARY:** But I'm not a lunatic.

**WARDER:** That's not fer ye or me to say. That's fer Mr. Girard to say. He be yer legal guardian an' he's the one who put ye here. By law whenever a legal guardian says the one they's guardian over is lunatick then we picks 'em up and puts 'em here. We got lots of women folks here whose helpmates has writ out a little letter sayin' they's lunatick. Seems to happen more to women folks 'count of the delicacy of thar minds.

**MARY:** Well, this has to be a dreadful mistake because no one has examined me. My husband said I was to come with you to see a doctor.

**WARDER:** Yep. That's what we tell most of 'em. "Jest goin' to the hospital to see the doctor." Works nearly every time. Sometimes tell 'em they're goin' to see the dentist. Jest for variety's sake. Lots of crazy folks looks jus' fine when they come in. I give you 'bout a month . . . I won't be able to tell you from any of those others. *(exits; Mary cries; FURIES enter)*

**FURIES:** **(Pg 76)** Don't be. Upset. Mary. Mary.

**MARY:** I have to get out of here. I have to see someone, talk with someone. When will they let

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me see someone?

**FURIES:** But we can let you. See ***anyone***. Just name the name. And instantly you'll see them.

**MARY:** I want to see my mother. *(FURIES exit, Mrs. Lum enters)*

**MRS. LUM:** Madam, you sent for me?

**MARY:** *(pleading)* Mother, I need you. **(Pg 77-79)** My husband abuses me.

**MRS. LUM:** For shame that you should give him cause. And double shame that you be brazen enough to tell it. There is nothing unusual in a husband's abusing his wife. It is the woman's place to be clever enough to seem to do his will whether she do or no.

**MARY:** And must the wife always bend to her husband's will, whether it be right or wrong?

**MRS. LUM:** It is the husband's place to rule his wife. The woman's to obey her husband. It is the Law.

**MARY:** Whose Law?

**MRS. LUM:** God's Law. When you married you vowed to honor and obey your husband, madam, 'till death do you part. Do you dare question the Law of God Himself?

**MARY:** If this is God's Law, as you say it is, why didn't you explain this Law to me before I married Mr. Girard? I was sixteen years old!

**MRS. LUM:** You knew what you were doing. You got the home you wanted and much more.

**MARY:** I have nothing, Madam, nothing!

**MRS. LUM:** Then you can only blame yourself. A wise woman never lets her husband know the distaste she may feel for him. You should have dissembled more and hidden whatever loathing you may have felt behind a display of feigned affection.

**MARY:** I would have been a liar.

**MRS. LUM:** You would have fared better. *(pause)*

**MARY:** I asked you here because I have desperate news. *(pause)* I am with child.

**MRS. LUM:** This is wonderful! Nothing in all the world can do more to please a childless man. Mr. Girard must be overjoyed.

**MARY:** I haven't told him. I fear what he might do to me, mother. It is not Mr. Girard's child.

**FURIES:** *(swooping in as Mrs. Lum exits)* **(Pg 84)** Whose baby is it, Mary? Yes, tell us, Mary. Tell

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us who the father is. Tell us. Tell. Tell.

**MARY:** The father is unimportant. He was someone warm and affectionate to me.

**FURIES:** You were untrue, Mary. You betrayed your husband. And broke your marriage vows. For shame. Shame, Mary. You will give birth to an evil thing. Only evil comes from evil.

**MARY:** I don't believe it. I don't believe you. You're trying to drive me mad.

**FURIES:** (Pg 88) Oh. We got us some cures here, Mary. Icy baths in winter. Splinters under the thumbnails. A white-hot iron on the soles of the feet for sanity.

**MARY:** But they would not do that to me, for they know I'm sane.

**FURIES:** How could they. Possibly. Know that?

**MARY:** Because it's true. **(Pg 90)** Bring Stephen Girard. Bring him now into this cell.

**FURIES:** No, no. Oh no, we must. Not. We can. Not. No, no, no.

**MARY:** Bring him!

********Scene********

**MARY:** **(Pg 91)** Why have you done this to me?

**STEPHEN:** I had no choice. You are insane.

**MARY:** Don't lie to me, Stephen. You know as well as I that I am sane. **(Pg 92-93)** When we met, I was sixteen, a servant carrying water through the streets. I laughed at everything then. And I was happy without even knowing it. Do you remember that girl, Stephen?

**STEPHEN:** She does not exist, madam.

**MARY:** No. We destroyed her, you and I. *(pause)* Didn't you ever love her?

**STEPHEN:** *(nonchalantly)* She was pretty. People noticed her. She was innocent, a trait few women have.

**MARY:** Innocent! And then she married you and thought she had gained the whole world, and in reality gained only this little room.

**STEPHEN:** She had everything she should have wanted.

**MARY:** The cost was too great. I was prepared to give you everything, but you wanted nothing. What good is reason without affection?

**STEPHEN:** If you wanted affection, you should have told me instead of making a public display

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of yourself.

**MARY:** Stephen, I made no attempt to hide my behavior from you. We differed in only one way. I didn't bring ***my*** lovers under your roof. I always maintained a respect for you and your pride. Perhaps I should not have done the things I did. But in that I am not alone. **(Pg 94-96)** When I was childless you blamed me. I felt I had cheated you out of a son. But it wasn't me. **You** couldn't put life in my body! *(pause)* I got more warmth from a stranger than you could ever give. It isn't my child that is loathsome to you, Mr. Girard, but the freedom of my mind. May God have pity on you, sir.

**STEPHEN:** God? *(pause; very calmly)* I do not know if God exists. If I thought he did I would pray that he keep you here forever. As I cannot be sure of him, I will see to it myself that you endure a hell on earth. *(exits)*

**MARY:** *(shouting after him)* All right! But my baby will live!

**FURIES:** She thinks her child . . . Will give her comfort. Not so, Mary. Oh no, no. No. You betrayed your husband. And broke your marriage vows. For shame. Shame, Mary. You will give birth to an evil thing. We will now show you what is yet to be. *(FURIES place a bundle in MARY'S arms)*

**MARY:** She is so . . . so lovely. *(to the child)* If I ever doubted that you were worth so much suffering, forgive me. *(To FURIES who gleeful)* Why are you . . . laughing . . . laughing? Tell me. She will live, won't she?

**FURIES:** Oh yes. Doubtlessly. Most definitely. The question. However. Is. How long? It will not be. A longish. Life. Months. Mary. Yes. Months. Five. Five months. Yes. Yes.

**MARY:** No! Oh no! My little one.

**FURIES:** Five months. Is. Quite enough. Then buried. In an unmarked grave. ***That*** you will have in common. Mary. You too will be buried in an unmarked grave. Here. On the hospital grounds. You'll never leave these walls. Mary.

**MARY:** Good! That at least I delight to hear. The sooner the better will best suit me. If God has any mercy it will be soon. Tell me.

**FURIES:** Oh no, you'll have to guess.

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**MARY:** A year? Two? Five? Surely no more than five.

**FURIES:** Yes, five! So clever is our Mary. Five. And twenty. Twenty. More.

**MARY:** Twenty more? Five and twenty years? I could not stand it.

**FURIES:** Well, most of it. Will be. There. In this chair. The Tranquilizing chair. The restraining chair. Bound down. Like the evil. Thing you are.

**MARY:** No! No! God would not permit it. He would not keep me living here in this hell hole for five and twenty years. *(praying)* Please dear God, sweet, sweet Jesus, be merciful to me and let me not stay here for such an age.

**FURIES:** Oh, isn't she funny! God won't hear you, Mary. Why should He? He's too busy. Besides He's set you up for it. It's God's jest, Mary. And the fool is. You!

**MARY:** Get away from me! I won't listen to you. *(shouting her prayer)* Please God, please!

**FURIES:** He made you beautiful. And you made the mistake of believing in your own beauty. It's been your doing. And your undoing.

**MARY:** *(still praying)* God, help me. Help me! **(Pg 97)** Where are you God? Please answer me.

**FURIES:** *(taunting)* Please answer me! Oh. Where. Are. You. God. God. God.

**MARY:** Stop it. Damn you. All of you. Where is He? And who is He? Is He another man? Then I'll have nothing to do with such a God. Damn you, God. I damn you!

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Lanie Robertson***
***Book: The Best Short Plays 1978, Pgs 66-99***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2004 National Qualifier***
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***ND State Qualifier***

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